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Patterns of U.S. Migration from a Mexican Sending Community: A Comparison of Legal and Illegal Migrants

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This paper analyzes differences between legal and illegal Mexican migration to the United States as reflected by the migrant population of a rural, mestizo town in Michoacán, Mexico, in which 75 percent of families send migrants north on a periodic basis. Data collected during 1977–78 on a total town population numbering 2,621 inhabitants indicated that immigration stutus plays a key role in determining the size and composition of migrating parties, the duration of time spent away from home, and frequency of movement while in the United States. Compared to illegal migrants, it was found that legal migrants, or holders of U.S. resident visas, tended to migrate in larger groups and were much more likely to be accompanied by wives, children, and non-working dependents. The average period of time spent away from home by legal migrants each year also tended to be significantly less than that of illegals. Finally, legal migrants demonstrated far greater mobility while in the United States than illegals, both in terms of distances traveled and frequency of movement.

This study is based on data gathered in the town of Guadalupe,[1] located in the state of Michoacán, at the western edge of Mexico's central plateau. The central plateau states have had a tradition of migration to the U.S., dating to the late 19th and early 20th centuries (Gamio, 1930). Within this region, Michoacán has always figured as one of the heaviest contributors to the flow of out-country migrants bound for the United States (Saunders

[1] Guadalupe is a fictitious name chosen to insure the anonymity of townspeople.

and Leonard, 1951; Samora, 1971; Dagodag, 1975; North and Houstoun, 1976; Cornelius, 1978). Guadalupe is no exception to this tradition. Migrants began going to the U.S. for seasonal work as early as 1911. For a number of reasons, the volume of U.S.-bound migration from Guadalupe has increased over the years, until today the majority of the town's population is heavily committed to seasonal migration as a way of life. Indeed, migrant income is the primary source of livelihood for nearly three quarters of Guadalupe's families.

This paper represents the first stage of analysis of data collected in Guadalupe from 1977 to 1978. The objectives of this paper are twofold: first, to describe the extent and nature of Guadalupe's participation in the seasonal flow of migrants to the United States; and, second, to examine existing patterns of migration and movement among U.S. migrants.

A primary focus of analysis is the comparison of migration patterns between legal and illegal migrants.[2] Theoretically, all the legal migrants from Guadalupe are permanent resident aliens of the United States. In fact, however, all maintain permanent residences in Mexico. While most enter the United States for varying periods each year, they do so not for the purpose of establishing permanent homes, but only as seasonal laborers. In other words, the great majority of these individuals use their "Green Cards", or U.S. resident visas (INS form I-151), merely as work permits which allow them unrestricted entry privileges. Few have any real intention of abandoning their homes in Mexico and settling permanently in the United States. These individuals exhibit very different patterns of migration and movement when compared to illegal migrants. The exploration and understanding of these differences represent the central purposes of this paper.

DATA

The data for this paper were gathered over the course of a twelve-month field investigation conducted in Guadalupe. The first author, an anthropologist, was principally concerned with documenting the effects of seasonal migration to the United States on the social, political, and economic structures of a Mexican migrant town. Guadalupe was selected as a research site for two reasons. First, the dramatic extent to which

[2]This paper uses the term "illegal migrants", or simply "illegals", to refer to migrants entering the United States without valid immigration papers. The term encompasses those individuals who are simply "undocumented" in the sense that they do not hold any entry permit, those who have obtained fraudulent documents, as well as those who have been granted temporary entry permits, the terms of which have been violated by overstaying the designated time and engaging in work.

residents were involved in seasonal movement to the United States, combined with their overall dependency on migrant income as a source of livelihood, made the town a particularly appropriate target for this type of investigation. Second, a preliminary survey conducted in northern Michoácan and parts of Guanajuato indicated that while Guadalupe may be unusual in the high percentage of its population involved in migration, it is similar to many other rural towns throughout the region in which a significant portion of the resident population migrates north on a regular basis.

The analyses presented in this paper are based on two sources of information compiled by the field investigator. First, a house-to-house census of the total population was conducted with the aid of six assistants recruited from the resident population. This census provided comprehensive information on the names, number, age, sex, and kin relationship of all household members in Guadalupe. Conducted three months after the commencement of research activities, the census was revised every two months over the course of a one-year period, adding data on migrant families who had not been present for the initial count, but who had subsequently returned. In the few cases where a migrant family did not return during the study period, data were gathered from relatives and neighbors. This census provided the base population from which all rates and comparisons were later constructed.

Because the general census data solicited were of a non-threatening nature, combined with the fact that the project was endorsed by the president of Guadalupe who urged all townspeople to respond, the gathering of data was conducted with little resistance from residents. To insure further accuracy, however, information was checked with a variety of other records, including an educational census conducted by local school teachers in 1976, as well as the files of two public works projects which contained lists of all town households, and the age, sex, and number of individual members.

The accuracy of this information and the completeness of census enumeration is suggested by Figure I, which presents the age distribution of Guadalupe aggregated by five-year intervals.

Aside from minor fluctuations, this age distribution is remarkably smooth for a small population. Certainly there is no evidence that a significant number of migrants were not enumerated. If such were the case, a clear deficit of population over the younger working ages (e.g. 20–40 years of age) could be expected. The lack of such a deficit suggests the essential accuracy of the population count.

Whereas general demographic data could be compiled by direct census, it was not possible to use the same method in collecting informa-

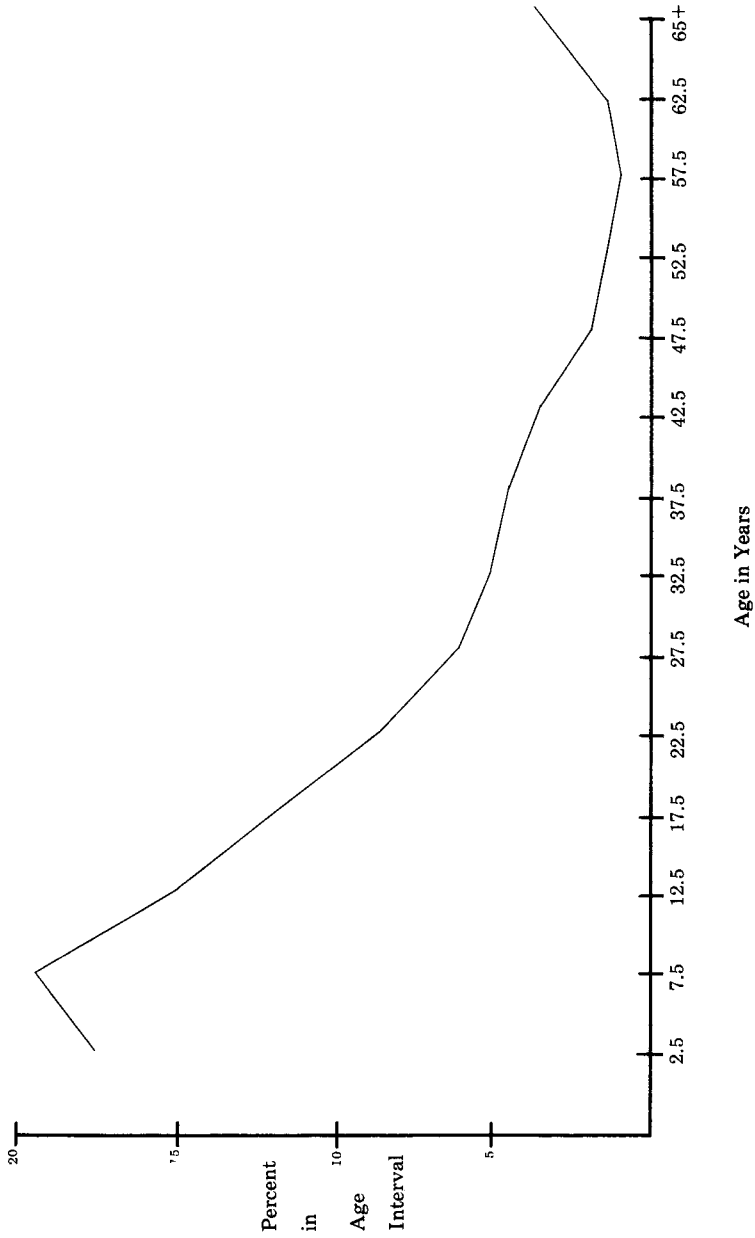

FIGURE I: Distribution of population by five-year age intervals, Guadalupe, Michoacán, 1978.

tion on migration. Large numbers of residents work illegally in the United States, and numerous legal migrants have obtained their visas through fraudulent means. Such people worry about being discovered and reported to U.S. immigration authorities, and are unlikely to respond truthfully to direct questions asked by any researcher, either Mexican or American.

To obtain data on migration, therefore, it was necessary to resort to an indirect approach which entailed gathering a diversified group of informants who trusted the investigator sufficiently to provide detailed information on other residents with whom they were familiar. Data sheets were prepared for each household and family, using the census information previously acquired. For individuals who worked in the United States, and for those with previous migrant experience, detailed records were compiled on U.S. immigration status (legal or illegal), points of destination, types of work performed, movement patterns and itineraries, numbers of trips made, and prior migration histories.

This information was acquired from individuals who worked in the United States both legally and illegally. Since townspeople who migrate frequently follow similar *corridas*, or migration routes, it was possible for informants to provide accurate information on many other migrants with whom they were in contact while in the north. A total of 26 informants, representing a cross section of the overall community in terms of age, sex, and occupational status assisted in compiling this material. These people were carefully instructed to avoid giving information about which they were not certain. All data gathered in this way were methodically cross-checked against other informants. In general, information on each migrant could be compared across a minimum of six informants, and usually more. When discrepencies were discovered in the data, further inquiries were made utnil the investigator felt certain that accurate information had been obtained. In cases where it was not possible to resolve conflicting reports, entries were classified as unknown.

This paper departs from previous studies on Mexican migration in its use of indirect methods to gather data on migration to the United States. Earlier studies (Cornelius, 1976) and studies currently in progress (Bustamante, 1978) typically rely on direct survey or interview techniques to gather data on this subject. However, field experience has indicated that direct questions regarding migration to the United States—legal or illegal—are not likely to produce honest and accurate answers. Because the subject of illegal migration is so sensitive, and because the migrants themselves feel so vulnerable, the authors believe that the indirect data-gathering methods described above are better suited to the problem, and more apt to yield truthful results.

GUADALUPE AS A SOURCE OF MIGRATION TO THE U.S.

The town of Guadalupe is comprised of 2,621 individuals living in 379 households, where a household consists of a group of related individuals living together in a common dwelling. Because joint family households are quite common in Guadalupe, the number of families[3] (465) considerably exceeds that of households.

Guadalupe's population is very heavily involved in migration to the United States, as can be seen in Table 1, which presents numbers of individuals currently migrating, as well as numbers of families and households containing current U.S. migrants.[4]

As is shown, 35 percent of the entire population of the town is actively

[3] A family is defined here as a married couple (or a widowed parent) plus all unmarried children, as well as other kinsmen living in the same household who are chiefly dependent on the family head, or principal wage earner, for support. Thus, while a married son or daughter living in a parent's home with his or her spouse and children would always comprise a separate family unit, an unmarried aunt, uncle, or other relative living in the same household would not unless they were economically independent.

[4] For most of the tabulations in this paper, individual families rather than households have been used as base units of analysis. The reason for this relates to the fact that many local households contain multiple family units with different characteristics. Thus, while two, three, and even four families may reside together in the same dwelling, large differences in occupational and migratory status, as well as annual income levels, frequently differentiate one family from another.

TABLE 1

NUMBER AND IMMIGRATION STATUS OF INDIVIDUALS CURRENTLY MIGRATING TO THE U.S., AND OF FAMILIES AND HOUSEHOLDS CURRENTLY SENDING MIGRANTS, GUADALUPE, MICHOACAN, 1978

	Individuals	Families	Households
Currently Migrating	919	342	283
	(35.1%)	(73.5%)	(74.7%)
Legal	723	194	154
	(27.6%)	(41.7%)	(40.6%)
Illegal	196	124	101
	(7.5%)	(26.7%)	(26.6%)
Mixed[a]	—	24	28
	—	(5.2%)	(7.4%)
Not Migrating	1697	123	96
	(64.8%)	(26.5%)	(25.3%)
Total	2617[b]	465	379
	(100%)	(100%)	(100%)

NOTES: [a]Families and households sending both legal and illegal immigrants to the U.S.
[b]Excludes four native born U.S. citizens married to Guadalupe residents.

TABLE 2

NUMBER AND IMMIGRATION STATUS OF INDIVIDUALS WHO HAVE EVER MIGRATED TO THE U.S., AND OF FAMILIES AND HOUSEHOLDS EVER SENDING MIGRANTS, GUADALUPE, MICHOACÁN, 1978

	Individuals	Families	Households
Ever Migrating	1095	410	335
	(41.8%)	(88.2%)	(88.4%)
Legal[a]	827	238	199
	(31.6%)	(51.2%)	(52.5%)
Illegal[b]	345	272	231
	(13.2%)	(58.5%)	(60.9%)
Bracero	130	130	128
	(5.0%)	(28.0%)	(33.8%)
Never Migrating	1522	55	44
	(58.2%)	(11.8%)	(11.6%)
Total	2617[b]	465	379
	(100%)	(100%)	(100%)

NOTES: [a]Frequencies for legal, illegal, and bracero categories will not sum to total ever migrating because they are not exclusive of one another.
[b]Excludes four native born U.S. citizens married to Guadalupe residents.

engaged in migration to the United States. Looking at migrancy from the point of view of households and families, however, the dramatic commitment of Guadalupe's population to U.S. migration becomes even more evident. Roughly three-quarters of all families and households currently send migrants to the United States.

Yet, even these figures do not reflect the overwhelming role that migration has played in the lives of Guadalupenos. Table 2 presents data on the number of individuals who have, at one time or another, ever migrated to the United States, along with the number of families and households containing members who have ever migrated.

Forty-two percent of the total population has gone to the United States at some point in their lives, and about 88 percent of all families contain at least one individual who has migrated north.

Two important points emerge from these tables. First is the extraordinary scale of Guadalupe's involvement in U.S.-bound migration. About three-quarters of all families and households—containing 79 percent of Guadalupe's population—currently send migrants north. Thus, almost 80 percent of all Guadalupenos are in some way dependent on wages earned in the United States.

The second point to be gleaned from Tables 1 and 2 is the remarkable number of migrants who are legally entitled to be permanent residents of the United States. Indeed, most current migrants are Green Card holders,

and a majority of Guadalupe's households and families contain at least one person legally entitled to U.S. residence. Of families sending migrants to the United States, 56.7 send legals (41.7% of all families) and 36.3 percent send illegals (26.7% of all families), while another 7 percent send both (5.2% of all families).

These legal migrants can in no way be considered to be residents of the United States in the usual sense. The vast majority of them return home each year after a period of temporary employment in the United States. Indeed, over 90 percent of legal migrants from Guadalupe returned from their last trip to the U.S. within 12 months of leaving (*See*, Table 8, below), and most of these (71%) returned in nine months or less. Since 1910, only 70 residents (11 family units totalling 57 persons, and 13 single individuals) have left Guadalupe permanently to live in the United States.

These figures suggest the possibility that a considerable portion of supposedly permanent residents of the United States are, in fact, *de jure* residents of Mexico, traveling regularly to the U.S. for periods of temporary employment. In the past, this possibility has not been fully appreciated by either scholars or public officials. Our research indicates that legal migrants may comprise a much larger share of the seasonal migrant flow between Mexico and the United States, and is a more important facet of the migrant phenomenon, than has been previously recognized. For many Mexicans, the Green Card has apparently become a *de facto* work permit enabling unrestricted access to the United States, rather than the permanent residence permit it was intended to be.

It is well to point out that these legal migrants are not the "Green Card Commuters" described by North and Houstoun (1976), *i.e.* Mexicans who live near the border and commute daily to work in the United States. Guadalupe is about 500 air miles from the closest U.S. border crossing at McAllen, Texas. However, none of the migrants from Guadalupe works in Texas. Employment is concentrated in California and Florida, so that effective commuter distance is on the order of 1200 air miles or more.

Migration between Mexico and the United States is largely a movement of laborers from areas of relatively low to relatively high economic opportunity. Table 3 provides figures on the number of current migrants from that segment of Guadalupe's population which is of labor-force age (defined as those between the ages of 15 and 64).

For this age group, the rate of migration is very high: 56.7 percent of all Guadalupenos in this age bracket are currently migrating to the United States. There are, however, pronounced differences in rates of migration by sex. While 75 percent of all males of labor force age are active U.S. migrants, only 42 percent of females are currently migrating. Females are particularly unlikely to be illegal migrants. Of the 247 female

TABLE 3

COUNT OF INDIVIDUALS 15-64 CURRENTLY MIGRATING TO THE U.S., BY PRESENT IMMIGRATION STATUS AND SEX, GUADALUPE, MICHOACÁN, 1978

	Males	Females	Total
Currently Migrating	415	247	662
	(75.0%)	(40.2%)	(56.7%)
Legal	272	213	485
	(49.2%)	(34.7%)	(41.5%)
Illegal	143	34	177
	(25.9%)	(5.5%)	(15.2%)
Not Migrating	138	367	505
	(25.0%)	(59.8%)	(43.3%)
Total	553	614	1167
	(100%)	(100%)	(100%)

migrants, only 13.8 percent were illegals (5.5% of all females 15-64), compared to 34.5 percent of the 415 male migrants (25.9% of all males 15-64).

These figures demonstrate, first, the very high rate of participation by Guadalupe's male labor force in the flow of migrant labor northward. Second, they reveal a quantitatively smaller, but nonetheless clear, participation of women in the migrant stream. Roughly 44 percent of currently migrating legals 15-64 are women (213/485 = .439), compared to about 19 percent of currently migrating illegals 15-64 are women (34/177 = .192).

This latter figure is higher than those typically published by INS and provided by studies such as North and Houstoun (1976) and Cornelius (1978), which put female participation at 10 percent or less of the illegal flow. The figure of 19 percent reported here supports North and Houstoun's view that previous studies, for various reasons, may underestimate the true extent of illegal migration by females.

The fact that close to 44 percent of all legal migrants of labor force age are women suggests the important role that women have come to play in the phenomenon of seasonal migration to the United States. These women do not simply accompany their husbands as marital companions. Indeed, for the vast majority of migrant women interviewed in Guadalupe, reluctance to be separated from their husbands did not represent a significant motivating factor behind their migration north. Rather, they went to work. Of the 213 legally migrating women aged 15 to 64 shown in Table 3, 198 (or 93%) performed wage labor during their last stay in the United States.

PATTERNS OF MIGRATION: LEGAL VS. ILLEGAL MIGRANTS

Size and Composition of Migrating Units

Migration to the United States from Guadalupe is understandable primarily within the context of the family. Wages earned in the United States are important principally as a source of family support and, if a migrant is accompanied north by other individuals, they are usually members of his or her immediate family. Moreover, wages earned by various family members (*i.e.* wives and unmarried children) are generally turned directly over to the male family head. Thus, there is a direct correlation between the number of working persons in the migrant party and the amount of money made during the year. For this reason, most migrants are eager to bring as many working family members north with them as possible each year to increase overall earnings.[5]

Table 4 breaks down families sending migrants to the U.S. by size of the migrating party.

On the average, families containing legal migrants send 3.5 individuals to the U.S., while families containing illegals send an average of only 1.3 migrants. Obviously there is a pronounced difference between the size of legal and illegal migrating parties.[6] Whereas 75.0 percent of all families containing illegal migrants send only one individual, the figure is only 21.1 percent for those containing legals. Moreover, almost no illegal migrant families send more than two persons,[7] while about 58 percent of legal migrant families send three individuals or more. This disparity in the size of migrant parties cannot be attributed to underlying differences in the size of families containing legal as opposed to illegal immigrants. Average size of illegal families is slightly larger than that of legal families (6.6 compared to 5.9 persons), so that all other things being equal,

[5]A minority of resident families containing migrant members are actively engaged in other support activities locally. Furthermore, for those families who do have multiple sources of income, they are generally of minor importance when compared to migrant earnings.

[6]Throughout this paper, migrating groups or parties are defined within family contexts. This does not mean that the entire family necessarily migrates. It simply means that one or more members from the family unit leave Guadalupe for common destinations in the United States.

[7]The one illegal migrant party containing five persons represents a highly unusual case where a man abandoned his wife to live with a woman in the United States and then returned to pick up his four children after his wife subsequently died of cancer. With the exception of a brief two-day visit to collect his children, this individual has not returned to Guadalupe for over five years. He presently lives in free union with a U.S. citizen and has a permanent job in an urban area in the western United States. Due to these factors, along with the fact that he has been ostracized by townspeople for having abandoned his wife while she was dying, it is highly unlikely that he will ever return permanently to Guadalupe.

TABLE 4

FAMILIES CURRENTLY SENDING MIGRANTS TO THE U.S. BY IMMIGRATION STATUS OF THOSE MIGRATING AND NUMBER OF FAMILY MEMBERS SENT, GUADALUPE, MICHOACAN, 1978

	Number of Family Members Migrating											
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10+	Total	Average
Legal Families[a]	41	40	35	28	16	16	7	2	2	7	194	3.5
	21.1	20.6	18.0	14.4	8.2	8.2	3.6	1.0	1.0	3.6	100%	
Illegal Families[b]	93	25	5	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	124	1.3
	75.0	20.2	4.0	—	0.8	—	—	—	—	—	100%	
Mixed Families[c]	0	7	10	3	1	2	0	0	1	0	24	3.1
	—	29.2	41.7	12.5	4.2	8.3	—	—	4.2	—	100%	
Total Migrating Families	134	72	50	31	18	18	7	2	3	7	342	2.7
	39.2	21.1	14.6	9.1	5.3	5.3	2.0	0.6	0.9	2.0	100%	

NOTES: [a]Send only legal migrants to the U.S.
[b]Send only illegal migrants to the U.S.
[c]Send both legal and illegal migrants to the U.S.

families containing illegal migrants would be expected to send more individuals north than those containing legal migrants.

Mixed families—those sending both legal and illegal migrants to the United States—is a residual category that is difficult to deal with because of both its confused legal status and the small number of families involved. Generally, the mixed classification accounts for different families at various stages in the process of legalizing the status of individual members. Mixed families were tabulated separately not so much for their own substantive interest, but to enable clear and discrete comparison between status categories. Thus, they are not specifically discussed in this paper.

A large part of the size difference between legal and illegal migrant parties relates to the fact that migrants from families containing illegals are very unlikely to be accompanied by wives and children while working in the United States. Table 5 presents families cross-tabulated by whether or not the wife was a migrant to the U.S.

According to the table, wives in 74.3 percent of legal migrant families go to the United States, compared to only 16.5 percent of wives in families containing illegal migrants. Thus, groups of legal migrants were about four and a half times as likely to include the wife as those of illegals.

Similarly, legal migrants were very likely to bring along unmarried

TABLE 5

FAMILIES CURRENTLY SENDING MIGRANTS TO THE U.S. BY IMMIGRATION STATUS OF THOSE MIGRATING AND MIGRANT STATUS OF WIFE, GUADALUPE, MICHOACÁN, 1978

	Migrant Status of Wife		
	Wife a Migrant	Wife Not a Migrant	Total Migrating Families With Wives
Legal Families[a]	142 (74.3%)	49 (25.7%)	191 (100%)
Illegal Families[b]	20 (16.5%)	101 (83.5%)	121 (100%)
Mixed Families[c]	23 (95.8%)	1 (4.2%)	24 (100%)
Total Migrating Families	185 (55.1%)	151 (44.9%)	336 (100%)

NOTES: [a]Send only legal migrants to the U.S.
[b]Send only illegal migrants to the U.S.
[c]Send both legal and illegal migrants to the U.S.

TABLE 6

FAMILIES CURRENTLY SENDING MIGRANTS TO THE U.S. BY IMMIGRATION STATUS OF THOSE MIGRATING AND MIGRANT STATUS OF UNMARRIED FAMILY MEMBERS AGED FIFTEEN AND OLDER

	Unmarried Family Members ≥ 15 in Migrant Party	Unmarried Family Members ≥ 15 Not in Migrant Party	Total Families With Unmarried Members ≥ 15
Legal Families[a]	64 (84.2%)	12 (15.8%)	76 (100%)
Illegal Families[b]	11 (25.6%)	32 (74.4%)	43 (100%)
Mixed Families[c]	9 (100%)	0 —	9 (100%)
Total Migrant Families	84 (65.6%)	44 (34.4%)	128 (100%)

NOTES: [a] Send only legal migrants to the U.S.
[b] Send only illegal migrants to the U.S.
[c] Send both legal and illegal migrants to the U.S.

children who could work to supplement the family income. This was not the case, however, for illegals. As is seen in Table 6, only 25.6 percent of all illegal migrant families containing unmarried children fifteen years or older included such children in the migrant party, as opposed to 84.2 percent of all legal migrant families with children in this age category.

At the same time, there are significant differences in the number of non-working dependents included within parties of legal as opposed to illegal migrants. Table 7 cross-tabulates families by the number of non-working migrant members (typically children under 15 years of age).

On the average, legal migrant groups each carry one non-working dependent northward, while among illegal groups, the average is next to zero. However, the average of one dependent per legal migrant party can be deceptive, since the average is "pulled up" by a relatively small number of parties that contain many dependents. In fact, close to 61 percent of all legal migrant parties bring no non-working dependents to the United States.

Among legal as well as illegal migrants, there is a strong disinclination to travel north with family members who cannot work. The difference is that while illegals virtually never carry non-working dependents to the United States, among legals the practice is reasonably common. The reason for this fact is clear. If a family member cannot work, the only

TABLE 7

FAMILIES CURRENTLY SENDING MIGRANTS TO THE U.S. BY IMMIGRATION STATUS OF THOSE MIGRATING AND NUMBER OF NON-WORKING MEMBERS SENT, GUADALUPE, MICHOACÁN, 1978

	Number of Non-working Members Migrating									
	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	Total	Average
Legal Families[a]	120	21	24	12	6	5	4	2	194	1.00
	61.8	10.8	12.4	6.2	3.1	2.6	2.1	1.0	100%	
Illegal Families[b]	120	3	0	0	1	0	0	0	124	0.06
	96.8	2.4	—	—	0.8	—	—	—	100%	
Mixed Families[c]	14	4	3	2	0	1	0	0	24	0.88
	58.3	16.6	12.5	8.3	—	4.2	—	—	100%	
Total Migrating Families	254	28	27	14	7	6	4	2	342	0.64
	74.3	8.2	7.9	4.1	2.0	1.8	1.2	0.6	100%	

NOTES: [a]Send only legal migrants to the U.S.
[b]Send only illegal migrants to the U.S.
[c]Send both legal and illegal migrants to the U.S.

incentive to include him or her in the migrant party is to prevent the long-term separation of family members. In the case of illegals, this benefit is far outweighed by the perceived liabilities of increased vulnerability and greater risk of detection. There is also a strong desire on the part of illegal male migrants to avoid exposing their dependents—typically women and children—to the risk of arrest and deportation. Among legal migrants, however, these liabilities are removed, and there is a certain motivation to carry even those who cannot work to keep the family together.

Time Spent in the United States

Migration from Gaudalupe to the United States is largely seasonal, and there is a strong tendency for migrants to return home each year for rest and relaxation during periods of the year when agricultural work in the United States slacks. This tendency is even more pronounced for legal migrants than it is for illegals. Table 8 provides information on the duration spent by migrant parties during their last trip to the United States.[8]

On the average, migrant parties comprised of legals returned to Guadalupe after 9.4 months in the north compared to an average of 12.4 months for those of illegals. Moreover, while the large majority of legal migrant parties (137 of 194, or 71%) returned within nine months of leaving Guadalupe, only 66 of 118 illegal parties (56%) returned within the same period.

Thus, parties of illegal migrants displayed a moderate but consistent tendency to remain in the United States for longer periods than those of legals. The reason for this relates to the high risk of detection faced by illegals while crossing the border. Studies have shown that once an illegal migrant has entered the United States and secured employment, the chances of his apprehension are reduced (North and Houstoun, 1976; Cornelius, 1978). Indeed, most apprehensions occur within 72 hours of entry. Thus, once across the border and working, there is a clear incentive to maximize earnings by staying longer. In this way, an illegal migrant can send or bring home more money, and thereby put off the time when

[8] Duration of last trip is measured as length of time spent away from Guadalupe, not necessarily all of which was spent in the United States. A small portion of time is typically spent in transit between the two countries. Moreover, illegals are often apprehended and deported. In many cases, these individuals do not return directly home after being ejected from the United States, but simply turn around and re-enter the country again. In fact, one Guadalupeno was deported seven times during the course of a single trip, yet, in each instance, was back at work within a few days. If an illegal did not return home after deportation, but re-entered the U.S. to work again, he was not counted as having returned.

TABLE 8

DURATION OF LAST TRIP TO THE U.S. OF MIGRANT PARTIES FROM GUADALUPE, MICHOACÁN, 1978

	Number of Months Spent in the U.S.					
	1-12 mo.	13-24 mo.	25-36 mo.	37+ mo.	Total	Average
Legal Families[a]	183	8	1	2	194	9.4 mo.
	(94.3%)	(4.1%)	(0.5%)	(1.0%)	(100%)	
Illegal Families[b]	96	13	7	2	118[d]	12.4 mo.
	(81.4%)	(11.0%)	(5.9%)	(1.7%)	(100%)	
Mixed Families[c]	20	0	1	1	22[d]	12.6 mo.
	(91.0%)	—	(4.5%)	(4.5%)	(100%)	
Total Migrating Families	299	21	9	5	334[d]	10.7 mo.
	(89.5%)	(6.3%)	(2.7%)	(1.5%)	(100%)	

NOTES: [a]Send only legal migrants to the U.S.
[b]Send only illegal migrants to the U.S.
[c]Send both legal and illegal migrants to the U.S.
[d]Duration of last trip could not be determined for 6 illegal and 2 mixed family migrant units.

he must risk another crossing into the United States. Legal migrants, on the other hand, can enter the United States at will, and remain as long as they wish. At the same time, they may return home during the off-season, after only eight or nine months of work, knowing that they can count on returning north whenever they please. In short, the net effect of illegal status is to induce migrants to remain in the United States for longer periods than they would were they able to migrate legally.

Patterns of Movement in the U.S.

Detailed information was collected on movement patterns and points of destination for Guadalupe migrants during their most recent trip to the United States. This data revealed a considerable degree of mobility among many individuals, as can be seen in Table 9, which presents the number of moves in the United States made by migrating parties from Guadalupe.

To derive the number of moves made by migrants, thirteen geographic zones were delineated from reports of where Guadalupenos had worked during their most recent trip to the United States. Six of the zones were different areas within California, while the rest were comprised of particular areas within the states of Oregon, Washington, Florida, North

TABLE 9

FAMILIES CURRENTLY SENDING MIGRANTS TO THE U.S. BY IMMIGRATION STATUS OF THOSE MIGRATING AND NUMBER OF MOVES MADE IN THE U.S., GUADALUPE MICHOACÁN, 1978

	0	1	2	3	4	5	Total	Average
Legal Families[a]	103	19	19	29	15	6	191[d]	1.2
	53.9	9.9	9.9	15.2	7.9	3.1	100%	
Illegal Families[b]	85	27	6	1	0	0	119[d]	0.4
	71.4	22.7	5.0	0.8	—	—	100%	
Mixed Families[c]	10	10	1	2	0	1	24	1.0
	41.7	41.7	4.2	8.3	—	4.2	100%	
Total Migrating Families[d]	198	56	26	32	15	7	334[d]	0.9
	59.3	16.8	7.8	9.6	4.5	2.1	100%	

NOTES: [a]Number of moves could not be determined for three legal and five illegal families.
[b]Send only legal migrants to the U.S.
[c]Send only illegal migrants to the U.S.
[d]Send both legal and illegal migrants to the U.S.

Carolina, Indiana, Pennsylvania, and Michigan. A move was defined as any movement between two of these thirteen zones (The location of these zones may be seen by turning ahead to Figure II).

Table 9 reveals yet another basic difference between legal and illegal migrant groups: legal migrants are far more mobile within the United States than are illegals. On the average, legal migrant groups make about 0.8 more moves between geographic areas than illegal groups—an average of 1.2 moves for legals, compared to 0.4 moves for illegals. Indeed, the vast majority of illegal migrant parties (71.4%) do not move at all once in the United States. This contrasts with the case of legal migrant groups, where only a small majority (53.9%) make no moves in the United States. Moreover, whereas 21 percent of legal migrant parties make three or more moves, almost none of the illegal parties do so.

Table 9 does not represent a fair comparison, however. Illegal migrants rarely travel north with dependents. Indeed, the great majority of illegals are individual males who migrate alone. Legal migrants, on the other hand, often travel north with their spouses and, in many cases, with dependent children. The presence of non-working dependents obviously restricts mobility, so that a more accurate comparison would be to contrast parties containing the same number of migrants and dependents. Such a comparison is presented in Table 10, which restricts consideration to migrant parties consisting of single individuals.

When size and dependency of migrating units are controlled in this way, the mobility differential between legals and illegals is enlarged. The average number of moves for individual migrants is 1.8 for legals and 0.3 for illegals. That is, on the average, legals migrating alone make roughly six times as many moves in the United States as their illegal counterparts.

When the distance of moves made between areas by legal migrants is contrasted with that of illegals, further differences in mobility between the two groups are revealed. Figures II and III present maps of migration routes (*corridas*) followed by legal and illegal migrant parties to points of labor in the United States.

These maps depict only those *corridas* beginning in southern California or Florida. These *corridas* encompass about 94 percent of the movement patterns followed by Guadalupe's migrant families. The few *corridas* originating at other points in the United States are not shown for the sake of simplicity.

Comparing the two figures, the great geographical mobility of legal migrants, in contrast to the relative lack of mobility of illegals, is at once evident. Whereas 37 legal migrant parties begin working in southern Florida, and then make a transcontinental jump to west coast employ-

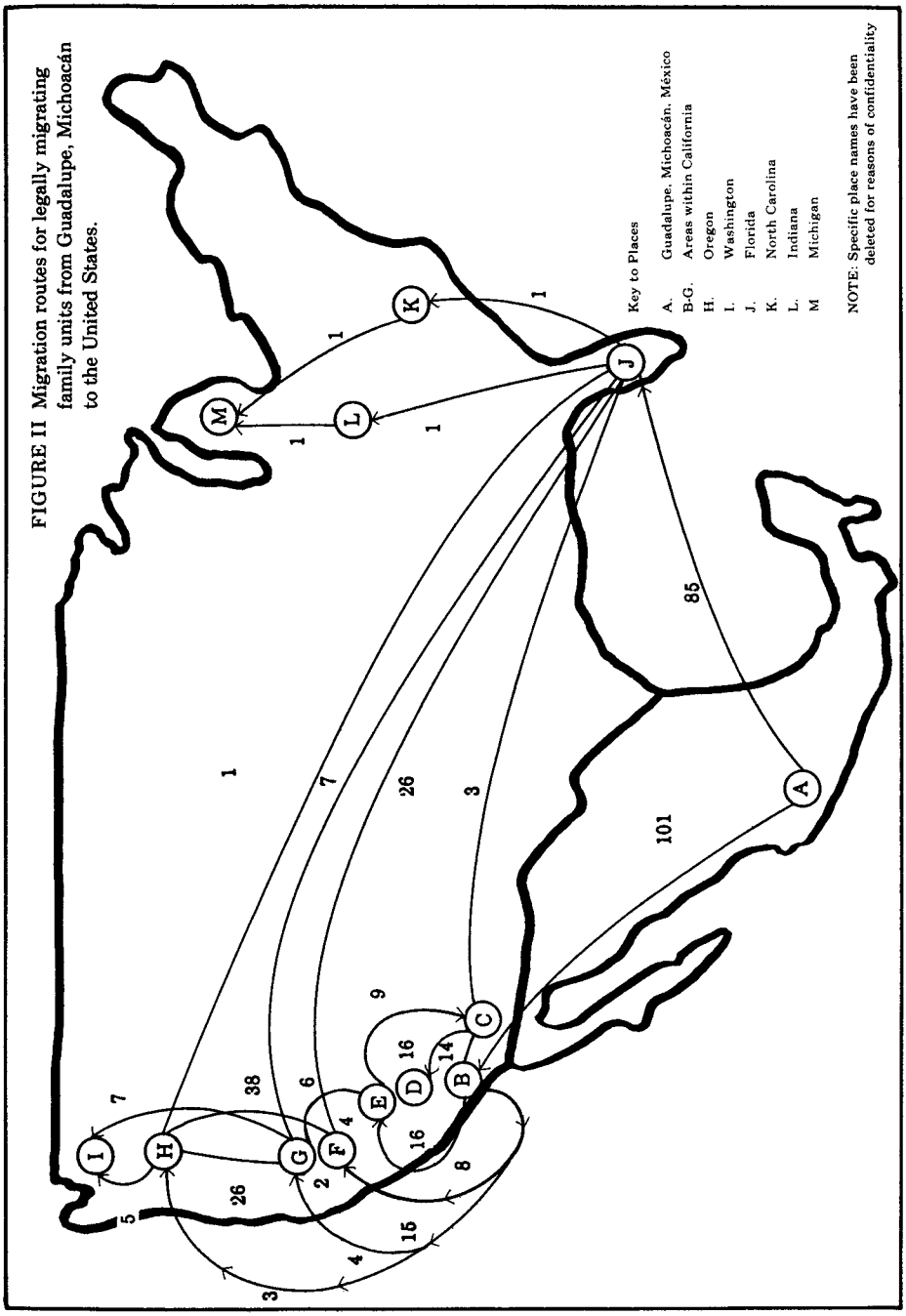

FIGURE II Migration routes for legally migrating family units from Guadalupe, Michoacán to the United States.

TABLE 10

INDIVIDUALS CURRENTLY MIGRATING TO THE U.S. BY IMMIGRATION STATUS AND NUMBER OF MOVES MADE IN THE U.S., GUADALUPE, MICHOACÁN, 1978

	0	1	2	3	4	5	Total	Average
Legal Migrants								
Travelling Alone	17	1	6	8	6	2	40	1.8
	42.5	2.5	15.0	20.0	15.0	5.0	100%	
Illegal Migrants								
Travelling Alone	67	17	3	1	0	0	88	0.3
	76.1	19.3	3.4	1.1	—	—	100%	
Total Migrants								
Travelling Alone	84	18	9	9	6	2	128	0.8
	65.6	14.1	7.0	7.0	4.7	1.6	100%	

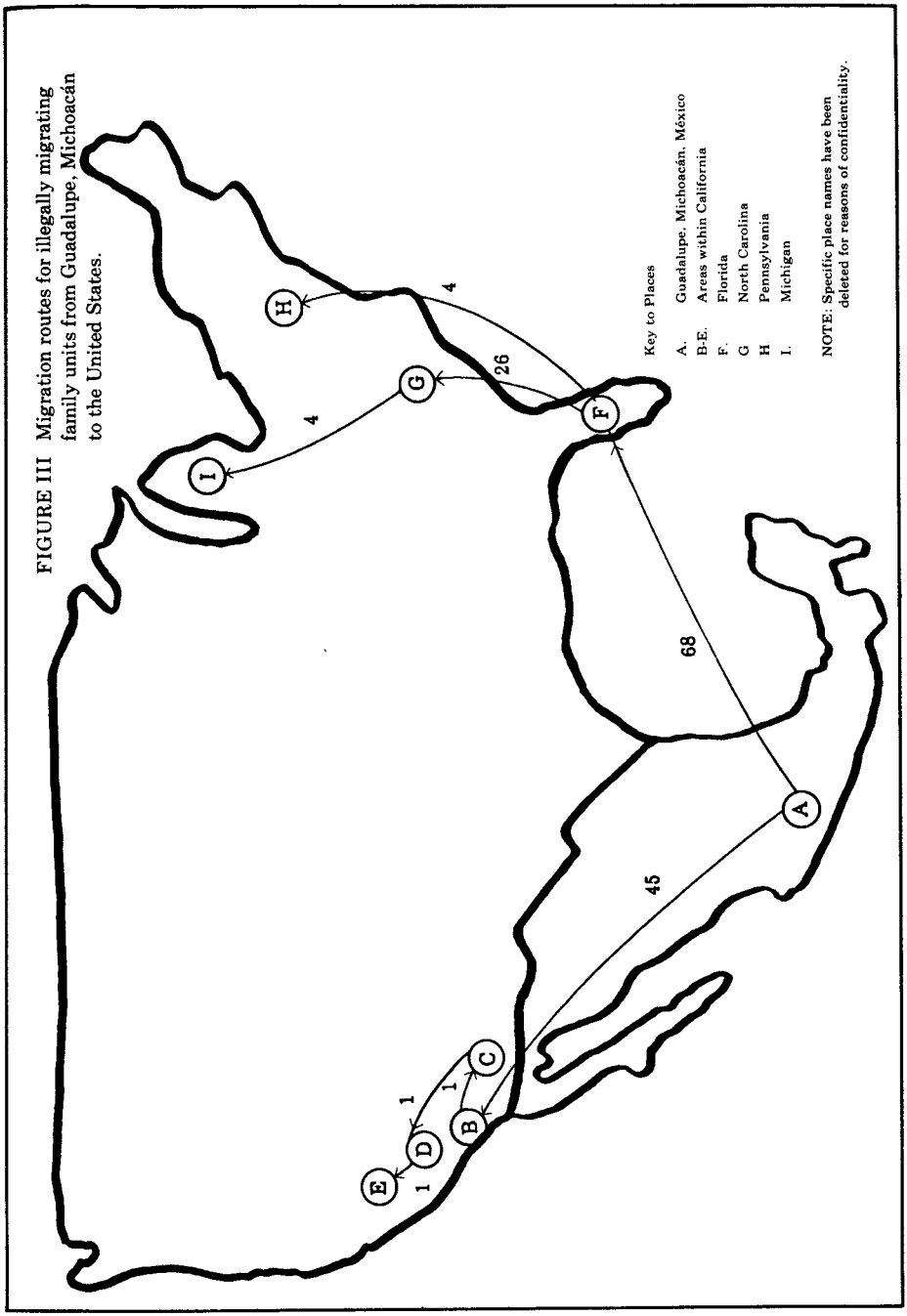

FIGURE III Migration routes for illegally migrating family units from Guadalupe, Michoacán to the United States.

ment, none of the illegal parties does so. Similarly, with one exception, there is no movement between geographical zones on the west coast by illegal migrants, compared to substantial movement between areas on the part of legals.

In general, there is a pronounced tendency for illegal migrants to secure employment in southern California or Florida, and to remain there, without moving, for the duration of their stay in the United States. The principal exceptions to this generalization are the movement of 26 illegal migrant parties from Florida to North Carolina (for the summer tobacco harvest), with four more continuing on up to Michigan for the fall apple season, and the movement of four illegal parties to Pennsylvania for work in the apple and tomato harvests.

These special cases are exceptions to the rule and go against the strong proclivity of illegals to remain sedentary. For the most part, illegal migrants from Guadalupe who move from one geographical zone to another on the East Coast do so as members of labor contractor crews. *Contratistas,* or leaders of these crews, arrange work, housing, and transportation for all individuals who travel with them in return for a fee—usually a percentage of their wages. As a result, illegal crew members do not have to deal in any way with employers, company representatives, or other U.S. officials. Hence, they are able to maximize their earnings by working at peak harvest times in different areas without increasing their vulnerability to detection. Were it not for this arrangement, however, the majority of illegal migrants shown leaving Florida would most likely remain there for the duration of their stay, and the number of moves made by these individuals would be virtually zero.

SUMMARY AND DISCUSSION

Data presented in this paper reveal a number of interesting points regarding the phenomenon of migration between Mexico and the United States as exemplified by the migrant population of a rural Mexican town:

1) In Guadalupe, the commitment to seasonal U.S. migration as a way of life is pervasive. Three-quarters of all resident families, about 79 percent of the population, are in some way dependent on wages earned in the United States;
2) The flow of migrants between Guadalupe and the United States is highly seasonal, with the large majority of migrants (over 90%) returning to Mexico for periods ranging between two and four months each year;

3) A large share of U.S. migrants from Guadalupe are persons who have been admitted to the United States as permanent legal residents. For most of these legal migrants, the "Green Card" is used as a *de facto* work permit rather than the permanent residence document it is intended to be;
4) A large segment of the migrant population from Guadalupe is comprised of women, a fact particularly true of legal migrants. Approximately 40 percent of females of labor-force age currently migrate to the United States. Moreover, about 44 percent of legal migrants of labor-force age, and 19 percent of illegal migrants of labor-force age, are women;
5) The legal and illegal components of the seasonal flow of migrants between Guadalupe and the United States differ in a number of important respects. Illegal migrants travel to the U.S. in much smaller parties than legal migrants. Compared to legals, they are much less likely to be accompanied by wives and children and almost never migrate with non-working dependents;
6) Illegal migrants tend to spend somewhat more time in the United States per trip than do their legal counterparts. Average time spent away from home is around 9 months for legal and 12 months for illegal migrant parties: and
7) Illegal migrants are much less mobile while in the United States than legals, in that they tend to make fewer moves between geographical areas (an average of 0.3 moves for individual illegals traveling alone, compared to 1.8 moves for individual legals). Furthermore, when multiple moves are made by illegals, they are frequently conducted under rather special conditions in which all travel, work, and housing arrangements are made by other persons rather than by the individual migrants themselves.

The relevance of this data to Mexican migration, in general, turns, of course, on the degree to which Guadalupe is representative of other towns and broader conditions in rural Mexico. Naturally, there is no way of really knowing this without conducting similar studies in other rural Mexican communities. However, a number of facts may be brought to bear to clarify the picture.

First, the case of Guadalupe is certainly not representative of Mexico in general. Typically, the proportion of U.S.-bound migration from rural areas is much higher than that stemming from Mexico's large urban centers. Moreover, Guadalupe is located in a region characterized by traditionally high rates of migration to the United States. While it is

possible to suggest that Guadalupe may be representative of other sending communities in traditional source areas for U.S. migration (i.e. rural areas within such central plateau states as Michoacán, Jalisco, Guanajuato, Zacatecas, and San Luis Potosi), it is probably extreme even for these traditional migrant areas.

As a result of various historical events, Guadalupenos were left with almost no arable land in the years following the Mexican Revolution. Consequently, an unusually large share of resident families are now landless. At the same time, most of the land that is owned by townspeople is of very poor quality. For many families, therefore, migration is the only rational alternative. It is reasonable to suggest that were it not for seasonal migration to the United States, substantial numbers of Guadalupenos would have long-since joined the ranks of permanent out-migrants to Mexico's urban centers.

While typical "push" factors leading to U.S. migration are exacerbated in Guadalupe due to its restricted land base, the town is not wholly unrepresentative of broader conditions in rural Mexico. As a result of a history of rapid population growth in rural areas, Mexico is plagued by a critical scarcity of arable land. The proportion of adult rural dwellers owning land fell from 42 percent in 1940 to 33 percent in 1970 (Cornelius, 1978), in spite of the transfer of land to some 3 million peasants since 1930. There are now an estimated 3.2 to 3.6 million landless peasants—more than existed in 1930 before the intensification of Mexico's agrarian reform (Hewitt de Alcantara, 1976). In short, there is a shortage of cultivable land coming at a time when demand for it, and the food and livelihood it provides, are rapidly increasing.

Hence, in many ways, Guadalupe is merely an extreme example of conditions already endemic to rural Mexico, where land shortages, poor agricultural conditions, low wages, a lack of employment opportunities, and an expanding population have forced many residents to migrate north in search of a living. While extrapolating figures from Guadalupe would certainly overestimate the extent of current migration from Mexico to the United States, they may be indicative of future trends if Mexico's rural population doubles in the next 20 to 25 years, as it seems likely to do. Cornelius (1978) has estimated that about 21 percent of Mexico's population is dependent on wages earned in the U.S. for their livelihood. The results presented here suggest that in many rural areas the percentage could be much higher. Finally, while Guadalupe inevitably overstates the extent of U.S. migration from Mexico as a whole, there is no reason to assume that findings relating to the relative size of legal and illegal migrant flows, and the various differences between them, are unrepresentative of broader patterns within much of rural Mexico.

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